

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
12/3/2025

The meeting was called to Order at 6:30pm by coordinator Sally Garratt. There were eleven people present. The minutes for the November meeting were approved as presented.

We discussed the proposed Equine Economic Impact Survey. Jennifer reported that she had contacted the 4H clubs on the Island and we can gather info on horse ownership from those groups. Connie looked into Pony Clubs operating on the island. She talked with one group but has not contacted any other groups that may be operating on the island. We concluded that we cannot find an outside group to conduct the survey but that we have the resources to do it ourselves by contacting local groups and horse related businesses. Leslie mentioned that the group would need better ways to communicate with the horse community. Sally said that Betsy had volunteered to work on communication issues. Sally will contact Betsy and have her contact the EEIS group to work on communications.

We discussed the organization and publication of the Whidbey Equine Directory that Thora at the Coupeville Chamber of Commerce has developed. Thora was at the meeting and she said that she is developing a QR code so that anyone can add information about their business or service directly on the Directory. She would also like to find ways to communicate about the Directory and will contact Betsy to help her in that effort. Rhed and Thora are the Admins for the Directory.

Rhed has been working on the possibility of acquiring Bell's Farm for an equestrian facility. She gave a presentation to the group of her estimated costs and projected income from running the Farm as a boarding and event center. She will talk to Leslie about the practical aspect of running an equine facility. Rhed welcomed comments from the group regarding cost related issues.

Other topics of discussion included a summary of the effort in Kitsap County to limit equine ownership by placing restrictions on property where horses are kept. That effort failed in Kitsap County as a result of a concerted effort through Facebook to organize horse owners and boarding facility operators. We need to be vigilant and be aware of any similar efforts by local (or state) regulators who might seek to limit equine ownership.

Several members brought up the need for an emergency plan for horse owners in the event of the "Big One". People who would like to work on this effort should let us know and the Horse Council can support and help with the effort. We will put this on the agenda for the next meeting.

The meeting was adjourned at 8:15pm. The next meeting of the Horse Council will be held on January 7, 2026 at 6:30pm at the Race Road Fire Station. We decided that since the first Wednesday of the month seems to be a good time to meet, we will be consistent with the meeting times and plan future Horse Council meeting for that date. Sally will reserve the meeting room at the FireStation for that date in the future.